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Boards UI Design review

25 October 2026 | Current implementation compared with the supplied design references

The current screen has a workable editor structure, but its navigation, block controls and toolbar need a coordinated layout pass to match the intended design.

Approved target: the reference layout with nested pages, board switching and a top formatting toolbar. Repurpose the bottom Templates position as an **Add page/section popup** trigger beside the user icons. Put the **Boards icon at the top left** and remove the AppFlowy icon from the top right. Colours and supported cosmetic styling follow the selected theme; layout remains consistent.

The main diagnosis

The strongest mismatch is structural. Separate navigation pills obscure the page tree, repeated plus/menu buttons create a competing column beside the notes, and the formatting controls are split across two uneven rows. The task-list spacing and stretched table insertion button are concrete geometry defects. Changing the colour scheme alone would leave these issues in place. [S1-S7, V1]

What should be retained

The prominent page title, visible location context, search, direct Undo/Redo access, checked task states and mixed content support are useful foundations. The reference supplies a clearer arrangement for these capabilities: compact navigation, a stable header and footer, and a consistent document column. It does not establish the appearance or behaviour of populated tables and checklists.

Highest-value changes

Level	Change	Expected result
P1	Rebuild navigation as coherent nested rows; add a pinned sidebar footer.	Hierarchy reads correctly and page creation/account controls stay reachable.
P1	Keep and organise the top toolbar; clarify editing and layout-lock states.	Formatting remains available with less scattered visual weight.
P1	Fix block-handle sizes and checkbox-to-label spacing.	The notes become the dominant reading surface.
P2	Standardise selection, content alignment, labels and theme roles.	The design stays recognisable and readable across themes.

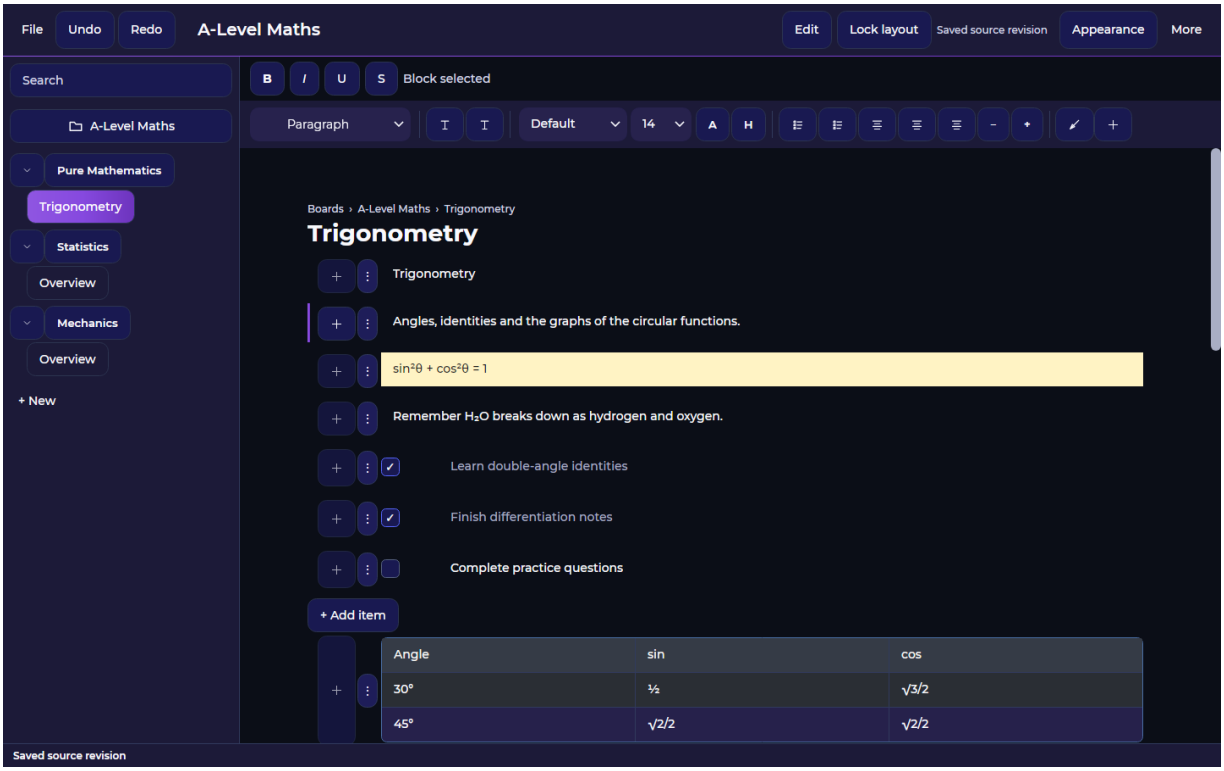
Evidence boundary: this review uses seven supplied images and one short reference recording. No source code or live application was inspected. Visible states are direct evidence; unshown behaviour, persistence and formal accessibility conformance require implementation tests.

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Visual evidence

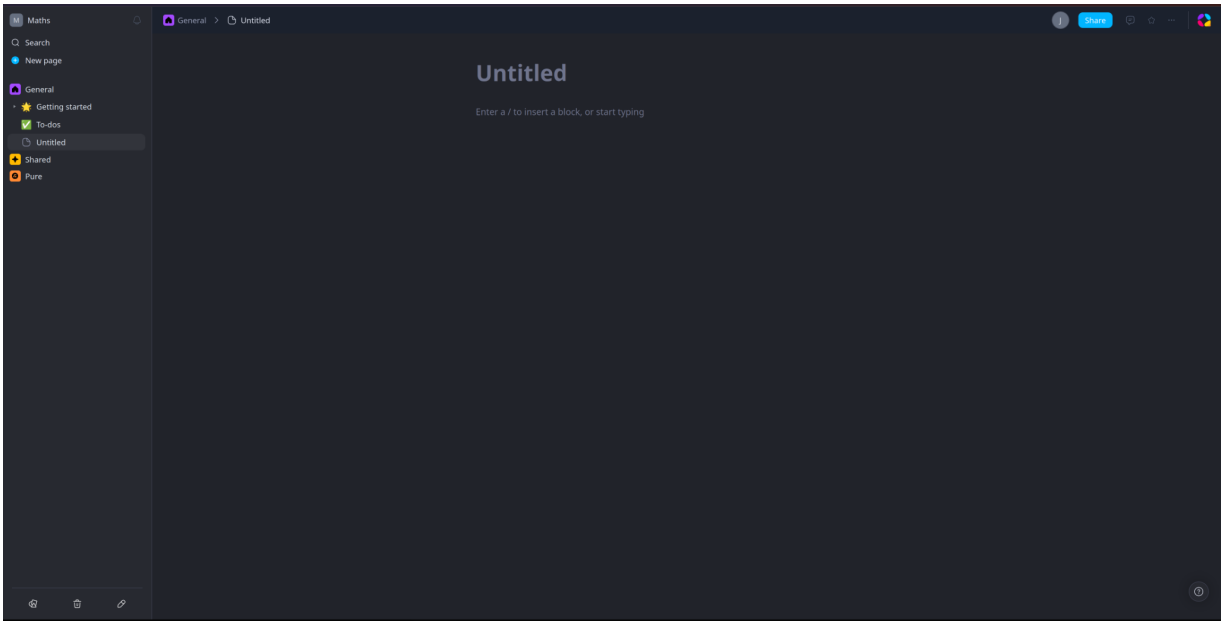
The original and intended screens have different dimensions and different content states.

Current implementation [S1] - 1,440 x 900 pixels



Visible concerns: separate navigation capsules, two formatting rows, repeated block controls, wide checkbox gaps and the elongated plus button beside the table. The table has a visible lower border; clipping is not established.

Intended nested-page structure [S3] - 2,048 x 1,036 pixels



Source images are shown unchanged. Target corrections: retain a top formatting toolbar; replace the bottom Templates action with Add page/section; place user icons at the bottom; use Boards branding at top left; remove the AppFlowy logo at top right. Layout stays consistent across themes. The empty page does not establish an exact document width.

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Layout contract

These structural requirements take precedence over incidental colours or empty-state spacing in the references.

Region	Required arrangement	Detail
Sidebar top	Boards icon, active board identity and Search.	Place the Boards icon at the top left. Keep the board name and switcher accessible beside or below it.
Sidebar middle	A scrollable nested page tree.	One row structure; depth-based indentation; a broad selected-row highlight.
Sidebar bottom	Add page/section popup trigger and user/account icons.	Repurpose the Templates position. Keep this footer outside the tree scroll area.
Main header	Compact page location and page-level actions.	Remove the top-right AppFlowy icon. Retain supported document actions; user icons move to the footer.
Below header	A persistent top formatting toolbar.	Group routine controls; use intentional overflow when width is limited.
Main canvas	A scrollable document with a consistent writing column.	Align title and ordinary content deliberately; allow wide blocks where needed.

Theme changes appearance; structure stays stable

Theme-controlled values can include canvas and sidebar colours, text colours, accents, borders, selected surfaces, highlights and other supported cosmetic effects. The theme must preserve readable contrast and clear states. The charcoal reference is one appearance example, not a required palette.

Structural values belong to the shared layout: where the sidebar footer sits, how tree depth is represented, toolbar placement, control alignment, content padding rules and scroll boundaries. The same viewport, page data and interaction state should produce the same arrangement after a theme change. Different viewport widths and accessibility zoom can legitimately cause responsive adaptation.

Keep the different creation actions explicit

Action	Location and scope
Create Board	Inside the board selector. Creates a separate board/workspace.
Add page/section	In the bottom sidebar footer. Opens a popup with New page and New section choices and a clear destination.
Add subpage	In a page-specific menu or another explicit parent-scoped action.
Insert block / Add task / Add row	Within the editor or relevant content component; each acts on that component.

The bottom control opens a popup so the user can choose New page or New section and confirm the destination. Remove the top New page duplicate. Board creation and local block insertion retain their own clearly scoped actions.

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Findings and severity

P1 = fix in the first layout pass. P2 = complete during refinement. These are design priorities, not verified functional failures.

ID	Evidence and impact	Required correction
P1-01	**Navigation hierarchy is visually reversed.** In S1 the parent label begins near x65 and its child near x43. Child text sits about 22 pixels left of its parent.	Use one row component with consistent caret/icon slots and increasing indentation at every depth.
P1-02	**Persistent block controls compete with content.** Plus/menu pairs occupy roughly x372-443 beside nearly every visible block.	Use a reserved, quieter gutter. Show stronger controls for hover, selection and keyboard focus; preserve touch access.
P1-03	**Task labels are detached.** Checkbox right edges are around x468; labels start around x529, a gap of about 60 pixels.	Start with an 8-12 pixel checkbox-to-label gap. Align wrapped text beneath the label.
P1-04	**The table plus button stretches vertically.** It runs from about y745 to y872, while ordinary handles are roughly 40 pixels high.	Keep control dimensions independent of block height; align the group with the top or first meaningful line.
P1-05	**Toolbar organisation wastes space.** Header and two formatting rows use about 170 of 900 image pixels, around 19% of the height.	Retain the toolbar, consolidate routine formatting and use contextual supplements for specialised blocks.
P1-06	**The required footer is absent from S1.** New appears directly below the tree; no bottom account region is visible.	Pin Add page/section and user icons below the scrolling tree; the add control opens a popup.
P2-01	**Editing state is ambiguous in the shown state.** Edit and Lock layout coexist with Block selected and active-looking tools.	Communicate current mode, selection and layout lock separately and accurately.
P2-02	**Save status is duplicated.** Saved source revision appears in the header and footer.	Use one clear primary save indicator; expose source/history details separately when relevant.
P2-03	**Content emphasis is uneven.** A bright full-width equation strip, repeated title and several text alignments compete.	Define consistent prose, callout, task and table geometry; preserve intentional user formatting.

Coordinates and dimensions above are approximate measurements in the supplied raster image. They are not claims about CSS pixels, source styles, click targets or device scale.

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Sidebar and board navigation

The nested-page, board-menu and footer references define a reusable navigation structure. [S2-S7]

One row pattern at every depth

Render each node as one coherent row: a disclosure slot, page/section icon, label and an optional contextual menu. The row highlight should span most of the sidebar width. Its content moves right as depth increases, while row height, icon size and baseline remain consistent. A 16-20 pixel indentation step is a useful starting design choice, not a value proved by the reference.

Reserve the disclosure slot for leaves as well as parents so labels do not zigzag. A parent label opens its page when that node is a page; the disclosure action expands or collapses its children. A grouping-only node should behave consistently with its declared role. Support children within child pages; do not stop at one hard-coded folder/topic pair.

Make navigation state coherent

Opening a page should update the selected row, breadcrumb, page title and editor content together. Keep the current page visible by expanding its ancestors when appropriate. Collapsing an ancestor should not discard the open page or its edits. Rename and move operations must preserve page content and descendants; a move must never make a page its own ancestor.

The footer popup offers New page and New section. Show the destination before creation: the current board for a section, and the chosen section or parent page for a page. A page menu can offer Add subpage with that parent preselected. Use the product's existing section rules; do not silently create a different kind of object. Board, section, page and content-block creation must remain distinct.

Pin the bottom controls correctly

The footer occupies its own region below the tree. Replace the reference's bottom Templates action with the Add page/section popup trigger and group the requested user icons here. Do not leave a New page duplicate at the top. Use a creation-appropriate icon and accessible name such as Add page or section; remove the old Templates tooltip and template-gallery action.

At short window heights, long page trees and increased zoom, the tree must remain scrollable and its final item must be fully reachable above the footer. Account menus should open into available space and remain within the viewport. Page-level Share, comments or history controls can remain in the main header where supported.

Reproduce the board-selector structure

The fourth screenshot shows the current board with a checkmark, then Create Board, Import Board with a submenu indicator, and Manage Boards. Use the board identity at the top left as the anchor. Keep these operations distinct from page creation. Preserve the menu grouping and clear selected-board state while applying the active theme.

Acceptance example: create and reopen a path such as Maths board / Pure section / Trigonometry page / Worked examples subpage / Example 1 subpage. The hierarchy must indent correctly, expand independently, show the right breadcrumb and survive reload. The footer stays fixed. This proposed check has not been run.

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Editor and content layout

The requested toolbar remains part of the permanent layout. The empty reference does not replace it.

Organise the top toolbar

Put routine controls into recognisable groups: block style; font and size where supported; emphasis; text/highlight colour; lists and alignment; insertion. Keep Undo/Redo and document-level actions in a predictable top location. One primary formatting row should be the default where space permits; an accessible overflow is preferable to tiny targets or accidental wrapping.

The current B/I/U/S row leaves considerable unused space while the next row holds most other formatting. Two rows can be justified for a genuine contextual toolset, but the current split separates related actions. Table and equation controls can appear when those objects are active. Use familiar symbols such as x^2 and x_2 for superscript/subscript if those are the represented actions; confirm the actual mappings before replacing icons.

Clarify mode, focus and selection

If there is a view/edit mode, show its current state accurately, for example Viewing or Editing. If the content is always editable, use labels that reflect that model. Layout locking should state its real scope, such as locking block positions, and expose whether it is on. Block selection, a text caret, a text selection and keyboard focus need distinguishable visual treatments.

Formatting state must follow the current caret or selection. A toolbar action must not apply to an old block because selection context was lost. Provide meaningful names and tooltips for icon controls; their absence cannot be inferred from these screenshots.

Make the document the main reading surface

Use a responsive document container with one deliberate alignment system. Align the page title and ordinary content to that system, reserving a narrow external gutter for block actions. A starting desktop maximum width around 760-900 pixels is reasonable for a prototype, with wide tables allowed a deliberate extension. The empty reference reveals only a left edge, so it does not establish an exact content width.

Keep plus/menu controls compact and equal in size for short paragraphs, checklists and tall tables. Their strong surface can appear on selection, hover or keyboard focus without making every block look active. Preserve a reliable visible route on touch devices. Avoid shifting text horizontally when controls appear.

Fix the concrete content defects

Tasks: reduce the roughly 60-pixel checkbox gap; keep checkbox and label in one row; align continuation lines under the label. Align Add task with the task group. Checked states are already communicated with a tick as well as muted text, which is worth retaining.

Tables: stop the adjacent plus control stretching with the table. Keep header distinction, align mathematical values consistently and give cell editing enough internal space. The screenshot does not establish a clipping defect or missing rows.

Equation and text: distinguish an inline highlight from a full-width callout. The large yellow strip should follow its chosen component meaning and theme. Preserve explicit user colours. The repeated Trigonometry block and chemistry sentence are sample-content concerns if seeded by the app; do not remove real user content automatically.

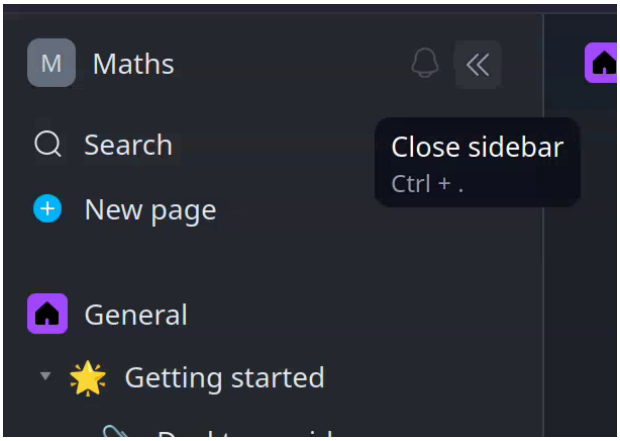
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Reference interactions

The additional screenshot and recording provide concrete states to carry into the target. [S5-S7, V1]

Sidebar hover and collapse affordance

The 10.44-second recording shows Search and New page receiving rounded full-row hover highlights. At approximately 2-4 seconds, a double-chevron control appears beside the notification bell with a Close sidebar tooltip showing **Ctrl + .** as its shortcut. This supports understated row feedback, discoverable sidebar controls and explicit tooltips. The recording does not establish a complete close/reopen cycle or successful page creation.



Reference frame: the sidebar control and tooltip are visible. The top New page action shown here is superseded by the requested bottom popup.

Slash-command insertion

S6 shows a popup at the writing position, with a scrollbar and grouped commands. Visible basic blocks are Text, Heading 1, Heading 2, Heading 3, Bulleted list, Numbered list, To-do list and Divider. This popup supplements the top toolbar. It does not replace the bottom page/section creation control.

Recommended behaviour: typing / opens the menu at the caret; further input filters supported commands; arrow keys move selection; Enter inserts; Escape dismisses and returns focus to editing. Constrain the popup to the viewport and keep its list scrollable. Insertion should affect the current location and remain undoable. These behaviours are acceptance targets, not all demonstrated in the still image.

Use Boards identity consistently

Place the established Boards icon at the top left while retaining the active board name and switcher. Remove the AppFlowy icon from the top right without leaving an empty divider or spacer. Do not infer that Share, comments or favourites must move; the user-placement instruction concerns creation and user/account controls.

S6 also shows AppFlowy AI, AI transcript and Ask AI Anything. These labels demonstrate menu structure, not proven Boards capabilities. Any adopted AI group must use the product's own naming and working actions. Do not reproduce another app's branding or present unsupported commands as functioning features.

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Themes, hierarchy and accessibility

Appearance may vary. The component structure and meaning of each state must remain clear.

Separate layout tokens from appearance tokens

Stable layout	Theme-controlled appearance
Sidebar/header/footer placement; scroll regions; tree depth; control order.	Canvas, sidebar, toolbar, menu and raised-surface colours.
Row geometry; icon/caret slots; target sizes; content gutters; spacing rules.	Primary/secondary text, accents, borders and focus colours.
Selection footprint; checkbox alignment; block-handle geometry.	Selection fill and foreground; hover/pressed styles; highlights and table fills.
Responsive behaviour driven by width and zoom.	Supported decorative effects and other cosmetic options that fit the shared layout.

Repeated control emphasis should remain subordinate to content in every theme. Blue or purple is not inherently wrong. Keep ordinary, hovered, selected, pressed, focused and disabled states distinct. Existing rounding is substantial; use consistent component geometry.

Preliminary contrast samples from the current image

Sample [S1]	Approx. ratio	Interpretation
Body glyph core #F8F8FC on canvas #0B0E17	18.20:1	Strong contrast in this sampled text pair.
Completed-task glyph core #A7ABC0 on the same canvas	8.47:1	Muted text remains legible in this sample.
Button fill #191951 against canvas #0B0E17	1.19:1	Subtle surface separation; not itself a conformance failure.
Button fill #191951 against chrome #1C1A38	1.04:1	Very little luminance separation between these surfaces.

Approximate screenshot diagnostics using the sRGB relative-luminance formula. These sampled values describe S1, not required theme colours. Actual styles, gradients, user overrides and interaction states still need checking.

Use the standards at the right level

WCAG 2.2 SC 1.4.3 generally requires 4.5:1 for normal text and 3:1 for qualifying large text. SC 1.4.11 requires 3:1 for necessary visual control/state information. A decorative button surface does not automatically require 3:1 if a sufficiently visible label or icon already identifies the control. [W1, W2]

SC 2.5.8 sets a 24 by 24 CSS-pixel minimum target, with exceptions including sufficient spacing. S1 shows small checkbox/menu shapes, but their actual click areas and CSS dimensions are unknown. Measure the implementation before claiming a failure. [W3]

Check placeholder text in the reference before adopting it. A faint Untitled heading is not a requirement. Keyboard focus must remain visible, and selection or completion should not rely solely on hue. Theme switching should preserve a reader’s page, selection and scroll context.

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Implementation sequence

Deliver the layout changes as one coherent pass, followed by focused behaviour and theme verification.

Stage	Work	Done when
1. Shared shell	Place Boards branding top left, remove AppFlowy logo, establish sidebar/footer, header and retained toolbar.	Regions and control placement remain stable as content grows and themes change.
2. Navigation	Replace pills with nested rows; wire board selector and the bottom Add page/section popup.	Deep nesting and board/section/page creation scopes are clear and consistent.
3. Editor geometry	Fix task spacing and table controls; align content and add the supported slash insertion menu.	Blocks share predictable geometry; insertion works at the current editing location.
4. State and copy	Clarify Editing/Viewing, lock state, insertion labels and save feedback.	The user can identify what is selected, what is editable and whether changes are saved.
5. Theme pass	Apply semantic appearance tokens and check every supported theme.	Colours vary while layout and state meanings remain consistent and readable.
6. Acceptance	Run the focused checks on the following page and collect comparison screenshots.	The same populated page meets the target at relevant sizes and interaction states.

Suggested starting geometry

The following are proposed design values for the implementation to tune. They are not measurements extracted from the reference, and they should not be used to override existing accessibility or platform requirements.

Component	Starting rule
Sidebar	Around 240-280 pixels on desktop; allow collapse or another usable narrow-window layout.
Navigation row	Around 32-36 pixels high; consistent icon/caret slots and 16-20 pixels of depth indentation.
Header and toolbar	About 44-52 pixels for the header and 40-44 for the routine formatting row; allow controlled adaptation.
Block controls	Fixed, consistent visible geometry with adequate actual targets; never stretch with content height.
Task label	8-12 pixels after the checkbox; wrapped lines follow the label edge.
Document	A constrained responsive column; deliberate extra width for wide content; bottom clearance above fixed UI.

Save feedback: use one primary indicator that accurately distinguishes Saving, Saved and Changes not saved. If two indicators serve different scopes, label those scopes explicitly. The current duplicate wording does not prove a storage failure.

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Validation and sources

Keep observations, proposed changes and untested assumptions distinguishable.

Check	Evidence to collect
Layout and themes	The same populated page and viewport in every theme, showing unchanged control placement and tree structure.
Long tree and footer	A long nested tree at short height; the last node and pinned Add page/section and user controls remain reachable.
Navigation integrity	Open, collapse, rename, move and reload a deep page path; retain content, descendants and coherent breadcrumbs.
Menus and modes	Board menu, creation popup, slash menu, caret and selection states; every action targets the correct object.
Input and accessibility	Keyboard and pointer paths, visible focus, accessible names/states, actual target geometry and measured contrast.
Content and scrolling	Long paragraphs, wrapped tasks, tall/wide tables, menus and the final block remain usable at narrow widths and zoom.
Saving and recovery	Dirty, saving, saved, error and recovered states; status wording matches real persistence.

Source register

S1. image(20261025-143534).png - current implementation, 1,440 x 900.
S2. image(20261025-143837).png - intended base workspace.
S3. image(20261025-143912).png - nested-page sidebar.
S4-S5. image(20261025-144043).png and image(20261025-144215).png - board menu.
S6. image(20261025-144315).png - deeper nesting and slash insertion menu.
S7. image(20261025-144458).png - footer Templates control to repurpose.
V1. Screencast from 2026-10-25 14-41-59.mp4 - 10.44 seconds, 608 x 428; sampled at 2 frames/second.

W1. W3C, Understanding SC 1.4.3: Contrast (Minimum).
W2. W3C, Understanding SC 1.4.11: Non-text Contrast.
W3. W3C, Understanding SC 2.5.8: Target Size (Minimum).
Official explanatory sources consulted on 25 October 2026. Criterion exceptions and full definitions apply.

Method and limits

Seven images and sampled recording frames were inspected. S1 geometry uses image pixels; sampled colours support preliminary contrast calculations. The user's toolbar, footer popup, branding, nesting and theme corrections govern the target. The empty reference does not establish an exact content width. The clip demonstrates visible hover/tooltip states, not complete functionality.

No absence of tooltips, keyboard support, persistence or equation semantics is asserted. The table is not classified as clipped. Duplicate/off-topic text may be user content. Numerical layout values are starting proposals. No live application changes or functional tests were performed.

Assessment confidence: 96% for the visible layout comparison and the interpretation of the supplied instructions. This is a qualitative judgement, not a statistical confidence interval. Runtime behaviour and accessibility conformance remain unverified.